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Laurence Juber Part II
(The Covid Interview)

The Covid-19 pandemic impacted the music and arts community particularly hard. Musicians who had previously been interviewed for the Fillius Jazz Archive graciously shared their experiences during this virtual shutdown period.

Laurence was interviewed via Zoom on July 21, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm filming for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have guitarist Laurence Juber with me today. Welcome.

LJ: Happy to be here.

MR: I'm not sure irony is the right word but I'd like to point out that four summers ago we had a conversation on film and we were face to face in Glasgow. And now we're having a second one and we're both on opposite ends of America.

LJ: Yeah. Technology, yeah. I mean you know especially, I mean I appreciate the fact that we can do this and I can do regular Facebook live concerts by virtue of the technology. I mean you go back fifteen, twenty years, it would not have been the same thing. And being able to play for a, quite a substantial audience. I mean I've had anywhere up to seven, eight thousand people on a — especially anything that's Beatle related tends to draw a much bigger crowd. But regularly — I think yesterday for my Monday session I had I think live was probably about six or seven hundred, and last time I looked it was over two thousand. So, because you've got the live audience but then as time shifted too, because it just gets instantly archived, so it's a way of keeping myself in shape, and also you know maintaining a relationship with an audience but it's not monetizable, at least not easily monetizable. And it's not really a piece of business as much as it's just an artistic exercise.

MR: Okay. Well that's a good way to put it. One thing I love about your show is what I'm going to call the face chords. Do you know what I'm talking about?

LJ: You mean in terms of whatever facial expressions go along with stretches, or, well you know playing guitar is a very physical thing. And you know for me it's, at my age now, I mean I'm, what am I 67? Yeah 67. The decisions — I have to make certain decisions about like how am I going to sit or stand, and how high is my strap going to be because there's a certain height where it stresses my left elbow, and if I'm sitting I have to make sure that I don't — you know it's either one side or the other is going to get — the arthritis on one side or the spinal, the L4-L5 on the other side. There's always some kind

of physical thing. But you know to counterbalance that, I'm not having to travel. So it's not getting on planes. And then more recently I've also been playing a lot of electric guitar gigs around L.A. which means I don't have to schlep a Fender Pro Reverb to the gig, which is, whatever it is, 50, 60 pounds worth of tubes and transformers and speakers and stuff.

MR: You are anticipating a question I had and that is let's suppose the situation very suddenly got better and things returned, are there activities, types of gigs and so forth, that you might choose to not do again, that you were doing before?

LJ: I would question getting on an airplane for gigs that aren't really on a certain level. And I've kind of graduated from doing the smaller gigs over the years, the smaller gigs, to more of the performing arts centers and you know, higher levels of jazz clubs and stuff like that. So I think I've been more selective about where I'd be playing. But the reality is that some of the smaller gigs are just going to go away. I mean some of these businesses are not going to be able to maintain their premises or whatever their business model is, is severely disrupted by all the shutdowns. I mean there are clubs around L.A. that I don't know are going to reopen. And on the acoustic guitar circuit there are a lot of more intimate venues that can't necessarily survive. So I think it's going to be a different era when we do come out of this. But I think that my focus is, having the time and not having to deal with travel has given me more of an opportunity to really focus on music and being able to, whether it's following up on guitar players that I used to listen to and haven't listened to in some years and I'll go on YouTube and then go down the YouTube rabbit hole. Like for example I'd long forgotten René Thomas who is a Belgian guitar player that worked with Stan Getz, who I would enjoy listening to thirty, forty years ago, and I you know, I had a portion of my record collection was stolen in the mid 70s and as a result there are certain records that I'd just forgotten about. And being able to find stuff on YouTube has been — because I'm a perpetual student of music and of guitar. And to be able to, you know, find video let's say of Oscar Aleman, who you know, is not necessarily as well known as Django Reinhardt, but is a great guitar player, and Josephine Baker's musical director.

MR: I did not know that, and I have to admit I had not heard this name.

LJ: Oh, fabulous player.

MR: It looks like California was doing the right thing and now seems to be going backwards. What's your day to day life like? Do you go out much?

LJ: I go to the post office to fill orders for CDs when they come in. We were getting out more, we've actually kind of scaled back because I think California's going to go back into full lockdown sometime in the next week or so. So, one second. Excuse me. But I mean I've done a few, I did a virtual concert from a local theater last month. I played at a

virtual gala where I drove down to San Diego. I mean I've done a few gigs. I've done a few sessions, like socially distant sessions where everybody is isolated. But mostly I feel like I'm going back to an earlier era before I really started putting out solo guitar records and touring, when I was active as a composer doing T.V. and movie stuff. And so, and there's a musical that we have that is in development that we were anticipating a tour later this year that's now pushed back into next year. So I've been working on arrangements and demos for that, and doing kind of virtual studio work. People send me tracks to do guitar parts. But the one thing that's quite different these days is that whereas it used to be I'd just send an audio track, now they want video too. And that's a little different scenario because whereas if you're building a guitar track for example you can do it a phrase at a time or a section at a time. Hang on one sec — you can do it one section at a time, but when you're doing like performance video, if they want a performance out of it you actually have to perform the piece you know, and it's a little different approach to the way of recording things. Right now I'm doing something for, there's an L.A. film conducting intensive where they assigned composers to write pieces for various instruments. And they asked me to be the guitar player to interpret this, and I just got sent three pieces that I've got to record and video myself doing, one of those, this week. And I've identified the one that is the most guitaristic, but there's another one that's kind of a cool electric guitar thing that requires either looping or overdubs. So I may end up just recording that on its own terms. Because it seems like an interesting composition. But there are that kind of thing where it's like okay give us an iPhone video. Well you know I'm set up here to do a higher level of recording than that, so I might use the iPhone for like a fourth camera if I want to do multiple cameras. So I've had to become a bit conversant with the video and streaming technology just to be able to stay on top a bit. And you know it's no longer being able to kind of fall out of bed, grab a cup of tea and then come into the studio. You know you've got to coif the 'do. And there are certain periods of day in here where I have stained glass windows kind of either side, and the light comes in. And yesterday I did something for a Beatle-related project where I kind of timed it so that the light was shining on my fingers so I'd kind of go to a particular chord and there would be this kind of flash of light. And it was kind of like, it was a cool effect. So I hope they like it 'cause it was fun to do.

MR: Speaking of effects, I'm going to just alter our view here for a moment. It sounds like you're about as busy as you could be.

LJ: Oh yeah.

MR: That's great. Did you have a time back, I don't know, maybe in March or something, a certain moment where you really started to believe that this pandemic was serious?

LJ: It happened very quickly. It was funny because I saw that there were going to be some travel limitations and I was actually, I was ready to get a new car, and I think it was March 10th I got a Subaru Crosstrek anticipating that I'd probably be doing a lot of driving in California. Because I already had to cancel a tour of Taiwan. And then when I went out to dinner with a friend on the 12th of March and learned that he had a number of colleagues who had been hospitalized because they'd been on a skiing trip to northern Italy, and realizing that it was in the community already. And then that weekend I had three southern California gigs, all of which got cancelled, kind of the day before. And at that point it was like okay we went into lockdown before the city went into lockdown, which for a while was really uncomfortable because we couldn't see the grandchildren. Since then we've now, they come over to swim and we just keep a distance. And there's a little bit of socializing going on, actually it's an interesting one, and I'm having a second socially distanced lunch with a friend of mine who is 87 now, Perry Botkin Jr. He is a composer, he is a TV composer who wrote "Nadia's Theme" which is the theme from "The Young and the Restless" that Nadia Comaneci used, which was originally actually a source cue from I think "Mork & Mindy" because Perry did the music for "Mork & Mindy" at Paramount. But what's really interesting is that his dad, Perry Botkin Sr. was Bing Crosby's musical director for 17 years, and kind of stepped into Eddie Lang's role, because Eddie Lang and Bing Crosby had a very close relationship. And Perry Botkin really, I think, and I'm kind of learning this from talking to Perry Jr. and from just doing my own research that Perry was kind of the link between the New York jazz studio guitar players, like Eddie Lang, and the L.A. studio players. Because Perry kind of made that move and really became very established in L.A. in the pre-Wrecking Crew era, ended up writing music, he wrote music for "The Munsters" and was, there's some interesting video of him on YouTube. He was in the "Birth of the Blues" movie with Bing Crosby, which I think is kind of an idealized story of the crossover of jazz from black to white musicians you know, with the — what's the jazz band that put out the first kind of supposedly legitimate.

MR: Oh yea, the Original Dixieland Jazz Band.

LJ: The Original Dixieland Jazz Band. Yeah. Notwithstanding the fact that you had many artists earlier than that. My focus has been, in fact since we were last together, my focus has been on the history of finger style guitar and the instruments. And I put out of folio last year with Hal Leonard called "The Evolution of Finger Style Guitar." And I started with transcriptions of lute music from 1507 from Petrucci's first folio of lute tablature, and then followed that through Baroque guitar and Renaissance guitar, Baroque guitar, classical, into the earlier twentieth century and really followed kind of the timeline and the stylistic areas and just how much — one of the things that really became evident to

me was how much the concept of the chord progression, like we experience it in jazz you know, rhythm changes or whatever, has its historical antecedents in the sixteenth century you had the Romanesque, the passa mezzo maderno — that these progressions actually still get used even today. You know the Romanesque being the kind of the foundation of the "Greensleeves" progression. And then in the baroque era the vihuela or the vihuelo d'espania progression, which the closest — the pop song that was written on that is "Green Leaves of Summer" is actually on the vihuela progression and you can find that progression from Corelli, Lully, through Beethoven in the Fifth Symphony Second Movement. Rachmaninoff, and into pop song writing. And how much these concepts of chord progressions really kind of date back to the sixteenth century where the dominant instruments were fretted string instruments like the lute and the huala in Spain and then the renaissance guitar. In the early — there were keyboards but they were still fairly rudimentary, and how that area of kind of crossover between folk music practices, popular music practices in their own era, and what became kind of musicologically defined as classical music. There's a very gray area in between all that. What's fascinating to me is how much improvisation was a big part of that, even through into the early nineteenth century.

MR: Can I ask you, you've played with so many people, you've been around the world. Are you still a citizen of England?

LJ: I have dual citizenship, I became a U.S. citizen in 1988.

MR: Yeah. Well my question is observing American politics and being familiar with British politics, do you have any thought about the political situation that seems to be accompanying the pandemic situation?

LJ: Well my thought is that, you know basically what we did on both sides of the Atlantic, society crashed into the Information Age. And we haven't sorted out how to deal with information, misinformation, propaganda, and all the political and power dymanics that go along with that. You know, whether it's a Brexit type scenario or what we're dealing with here in terms of the politicization of simple precautions like wearing masks. I think that it's a product of us not really being well prepared to deal with the amount of information that we're given. And it's great being able to access all this, centuries worth of music on YouTube at no cost except maybe the occasional ad for dishwashing soap or whatever. But the downside of it is that we really don't have an easy mechanism for processing information short of spending a great deal of time — what I do, you know when I wake up at dawn typically, the first thing I do is I have a group of websites that I look at across the spectrum to see kind of what one side or the other is pushing as their particular agenda, and then try and find the middle ground where you can at least have some sense of what objective truth is. But you know at the end of the day I'm a guitar

player and I'll cast my vote on election day, or before if I do mail in, which you know I think is probably the sensible thing to do. But you know it's like I have my opinions. In high school I mean until my senior year my two main books of study were *1984* and *Brave New World*. And I didn't realize at the time — I thought they were novels. It turned out they're actually manuals for how to deal with the future you know.

MR: When you do go out, or on the gigs you're able to play, have you observed positive and/or negative behavior by your fellow citizens?

LJ: Well where I am, this is a fairly quiet neighborhood. And when we go out, we walk the dogs three times a day and we wear our masks and our neighbors wear their masks. And we've not really seen anything in our immediate locality that I could point to and say that's just irresponsible. You know but L.A. is a big place, and you know, I think one of the things, again, talking about information and data is that we don't really get a clear picture as to the granular detail. You know you get these kind of gross numbers on the number of cases for example. But you don't really get a clear, easy breakdown on where those numbers are being generated. You have to start digging deeper to find out, let's say there's a big hot spot but typically these are prisons, meat packing factories, churches, anywhere where you have a lot of people in an enclosed space and no real precautions being taken. So, and that I imagine is a full time job for an epidemiologist, let alone a guitar player. So you know I just have to kind of stand back and say okay, I'm just going to do my thing, which is to be responsible, and you know part of that responsibility is to at least use my skill set to entertain people who are on the front lines. I mean there are a number of people who watch or listen to my Facebook live who are in emergency rooms. And you know kind of they'll go into the break room for 15 minutes to relax for a bit. And so that's kind of a pro bono thing. And that's the best I can do under those circumstances, but it also is beneficial to me because I am able to maintain my technique and repertoire and, you know, the thing that took me a little while was to get used to the idea of performing for an audience that were only there by virtue of me being able to see comments. It's like being on television where you just have to imagine the audience that you're performing to. A little better than television because you do get that immediate feedback. But at the same time you know when I'm playing my eyes are closed or I'm not watching every comment as it goes by. I can only glance up occasionally or in between tunes. So from a performance perspective that has been a challenge because I've had to really learn how to focus in that way. And being in a studio, you know typically in a studio situation you get to do re-takes of things and you know I have to be able to, as one does, play through the memory lapses or the places where the fingers kind of get tied up in knots or whatever, and just have that kind of propulsion to, you know, to create an entertaining and engaging performance. But it takes a lot of preparation too. Because now

I've got it down to like Monday is "Moody Monday" so my repertoire is stuff that is either minor key or has a certain kind of moodiness to it. Wednesdays have now become "Workshop Wednesdays" because the audience, they like hearing about guitars and hearing differences with guitars. So this week is my archtops. Last week was my Martin flattops, starting with my 1893 parlor guitar. This one. 1893. So it's pretty amazing and it weighs nothing.

MR: I think I was watching when someone wrote in and said, "Well how many guitars do you own?" Answer?

LJ: I forget what I answered, as many as I need certainly. But the thing is that kind of this "Moody Monday," "Wednesday Workshop" and "Finger Buster Friday" each one of those requires that I do work in advance. I kind of identify, okay, when a request comes in and I have to say okay is this something that I've already arranged and not played since I recorded it, and then have to revisit that, or is it something that I have to pull out of the hat as it were. But one of the things, you know I spent a lot of time really concentrating on altered tunings and very meticulous arrangements of things. But the counterbalance to that is I've spent over the last few years, especially as I've done more jazz gigs, a lot more improvisation. And so looking for the opportunity to be able to dive into a Gershwin tune or Harold Arlen tune or something, in a way where I'm not having to also kind of recall the intricacy of an altered tuning arrangement but just be able to be in standard tuning and just go for the gusto. My friend Lee, Lee Newman, is the grandson of Jimmy McHugh, the songwriter. And so I've thrown in, on my last "But One" album I did "I Can't Give You Anything But Love, Baby" and I just, for Lee, recently did a "I'm in the Mood for Love" I did a recording of that for him, and I did "Sunny Side of the Street" too, which are all Jimmy McHugh songs. And I like to be able to kind of pull out something from that era and just be able to launch into the improvisational aspects of it. I miss having a rhythm section, however. But that's something to be determined. There's a local studio that I just found out has set it up where each one of its recording rooms is now set up so that each musician can be in their own room and they have linkage between all the different rooms. So even though we couldn't be on the same stage, we could be performing together and streaming it. So that's something to consider. But it's still not the same as having an audience there too, to get that feedback from.

MR: Isolation booths have taken on an added meaning, yeah. So people who watch this are going to want to know, over your right shoulder is a shiny record and over your left shoulder —

LJ: The shiny record, that's a platinum album for Wings, "Back to the Egg."

MR: Okay.

LJ: I was in Wings from ’78 to ’81. And the picture next to that is Paul McCartney with a concertina sitting on the balcony of a castle, a twelfth century castle on the south coast of England when we were recording. The one above that is Linda McCartney at a Hammond B3 organ, and you can’t really see clearly but on top of the organ there is a pack of Senior Service, Players Senior Service cigarettes, no filtertips, which is what Paul smoked at the time. There’s a cup of tea, a scotch and Coke, a bunch of boxes of Kodak recording film at which you could run a very high ISO so you didn’t have to use flash, because flash photography in a studio situation is kind of a no-no. It’s too distracting. And that was during the Rockestra session when we had not only Wings in Abbey Road Studio, but we also had the, it was like members of the Who, Pink Floyd, Led Zeppelin, it was crazy. It was a rock orchestra. This side, that’s me with Wings when we were filming a video of a hit song we had called “Goodnight Tonight.” And so the Hammersmith Palais, which is a venue in London with a revolving stage that I used to play at when I was just getting into studio work. I played with, there was a band, Ken MacIntosh, who was a band leader and had one of those kind of three saxes and two trumpets, trombone, rhythm section kind of playing hits of the day. And it was always good sight reading practice for me. And then let’s see up top is an award I got of my co-composing of the score of “Diablo 3” which was a videogame that I did composing on. And then below that is a picture that Mike McCartney, Paul’s brother took in I think 1961 of Paul, John and Gene Vincent at the Cavern Club in Liverpool. And then below that is just a bunch of acoustic guitars.

MR: Well I have a burning question here, do your grandchildren get to play with your guitars?

LJ: My eldest just started playing. My youngest just started piano lessons yesterday. Yeah, they’re seven and five so they’re still a little bit on the young side. Because my guitars, other than a ukulele or two, my guitars are kind of adult sized guitars.

MR: Yeah. Well I have grandchildren the same age.

LJ: Oh there you go. Fun.

MR: Yeah. Well Laurence I want to thank you for your time and I admire how busy you have remained and your Tea Time with Laurence Juber, and the success.

LJ: Yeah, but you know our whole family, I mean Hope, my wife Hope is, other than working with me on the musical that we’re developing, she’s involved in production of a potential TV show. My eldest daughter, Nico, has written a musical, which she did a Zoom reading of last week with a bunch of really high level New York talent. And then my youngest, Ilsey, has become a very successful songwriter. And she is busy writing and hasn’t stopped, you know, learned how to run Pro Tools so she can record vocals at home. Everybody in the family is just really busy. So happily we’re in a position where we have that flexibility. I mean having — me having done studio work for as long as I have, you know I get a pension from the Musicians Union, and Social Security, and then

I've got a revenue stream from royalties on thirty albums that I've recorded, you know stuff that gets played on Sirius and Pandora, Spotify, and it all kind of keeps things afloat without having the pressure of having to deal with the fact that there's no money gigs. So, but I miss the live experience obviously.

MR: Well we hope it comes back as soon as possible, and I have a feeling that all of us who miss it so badly, that first gig is just going to be like terrific. You get that heart started.

LJ: Yeah. All right then.

MR: Thank you very much for your time.

LJ: Oh you're very welcome, and I enjoyed the conversation, and anytime.

MR: Okay.

LJ: All right then.

MR: Over and out.

LJ: Right. Stay safe, cheers.